They were outside the hotel at all hours, waiting to catch us getting on and off the bus on our way to practice. I did my best not to be affected by it all. It helped that the practice sessions were just the same as they'd always been and I batted in the nets and played football with the boys just as I had always done.

Sporting the tricolour

One thing I was looking forward to was playing with some special new bat stickers and grips. The design featured the tricolour and I had worked closely on it with my sponsors Adidas and my manager Vinod Naidu. The stickers had been specially designed for my last game and they were never going to go on any other bat in the market. I looked forward to revealing them when I batted in my 200th and final Test match.

The stickers and grips arrived the day before the game and I didn't want to let anyone see them till the morning of the match. I borrowed Rohit Sharma's bag to take all my bats to my room, where I spent hours changing the stickers and putting on the new grips. I have always worked on my bats myself and have spent many happy hours doing repairs over the years. I enjoyed the close connection with the tools of my trade and the rest of the team often took advantage of this. If anyone wanted sandpaper, glue or bat tape, bat coat, grip or gripper, it was me they would come to.

I couldn't resist taking a picture of the new-look bats to send to Anjali. I was very happy with the way they had turned out. The tricolour has always meant the world to me and this was my way of showing respect to my country. I was looking forward to using them the next morning. As I was packing my clothes and other things to take to the ground the following day, my sense of excitement was also tinged with sadness at the thought that I only had a few days left.

14 November 2013, day one of the final Test

After a good night's sleep, I got up at my usual time on the morning of the first day. I made my own tea in the room, which I have always done, and went through my routine of taking a shower and doing my prayers before putting on my headphones and going down to board the team bus, which was surrounded by at least a thousand people.